D&D Starter Set: Heroes of the Borderlands Public Play Guidance

The *D&D Starter Set: Heroes of the Borderlands* is the newest introductory D&D set, and uses many components to create an attractive, easy, and fun way for prospective players to learn how to play D&D. What follows is guidance for conventions, game stores, and other public play experiences.

Organizer Notes

Unlike other starter products, *Heroes of the Borderlands* has a strict maximum of four players plus one Dungeon Master. It should not be attempted to run sessions of play with more than four players, as it requires multiple box sets and doubling up on character classes is not optimal.

Everything is included to play in the box – there is no need to reference anything outside of the components inside the box.

Dungeon Mastering

Heroes of the Borderlands is easy to pick up and Dungeon Master. If you as the organizer have scheduled a longer learn-to-play session, you may decide to have the players pick a Dungeon Master from their group. If you are running demos only (see below), this is not recommended.

For both the demo and the two-hour session below, you won't need the **Keep on the Borderlands Booklet**.

Demo Experience

To run a short, approximately 20-minute demo of D&D, set up as follows:

- From the **Wilderness Booklet**, choose Region 1: Trail and set up the Bandit Ambush encounter. Remove one Bandit.
- Set up each player board (Cleric, Fighter, Rogue, Wizard) on the level 1 side in a static location at the table. Choose a species and background for each. Place the remainder of the cards needed for each board near the board.
- Set out the remaining components, such as the Trail map, monster cards, and the tokens for the players and bandits.
- When players arrive, each one chooses a seat. When they leave, reset the player boards for the next group.
- Players can share dice from the boxed set.
- Jump into the action, as you have limited time. You can use the script below to begin.

> Hi everyone. I'm going to run you through a quick demo on how to play D&D. I'm the Dungeon Master, so it's my job to tell you what's happening in the world around you and rolling any dice for the foes. You're playing the heroes!
>
> Just about anything you can think of to try will require some combination of skill, natural ability, and luck to pull off. And the D&D game represents that by having you roll one of these 20-sided dice and add a number from your sheet. Let's begin!

Two Hour Learn-to-Play

For a longer, more involved session lasting 90 minutes to two hours, set up as follows:

- From the **Caves of Chaos Booklet**, choose Cave B: Mephit Lair.
- Set out the Mephit Lair map and prepare the monster cards and tokens you will need. Keep the rest of the components and player boards nearby, but do not set them up yet.
- When the players arrive, each of them selects a character to play, as well as their species and background. Give them all of their components needed for play. You can use the **Quick Start Guide** to help you set things up this way.
- If you decide to have one player take on the role of Dungeon Master, you'll want to have a facilitator nearby to help with questions. They use the **Quick Start Guide** to set up.
- Players can share dice from the boxed set.
- If needed, you may modify the demo script to introduce the game (see read-aloud text above).
- When the players complete the session, leave the map, monster cards and associated tokens out, but you may put the rest of the components back in the box or in a neat pile nearby for another group.

After the Session

Make sure to let the players know about the new *Player's Handbook* as well as D&D Beyond! If you have other play experiences at your event that are good for new players, tell them how they can participate.

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